

SHADOWS OF THE FORGOTTEN SHRINE

by Helm Evans



SHADOWS OF THE FORGOTTEN SHRINE

A D&D 5e Adventure for Levels 1–3

3–5 players · 3–4 sessions · 8–12 hours

THE SHATTERED VEIL

Book 1 of 5

by Helm Evans

TUCO ENTERPRISES · TUCO.ENTERPRISES

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ADVENTURE SUMMARY

A dark fantasy horror mystery for levels 1-3

SUMMARY

Three villagers have vanished from the farming community of Thornhaven, drawn into the ancient Blackwood Forest by whispered dreams and pale blue lights. The characters investigate the disappearances, navigate the unsettling forest, discover a forgotten shrine buried beneath centuries of growth, and must ultimately decide the fate of the entity sealed beneath it.

Can the seal be reinforced? Should it be destroyed? Or can the entity be banished entirely? The party's choices will determine the fate of Thornhaven — and the missing villagers.

ADVENTURE DETAILS

System	D&D 5e
Levels	1-3
Sessions	3-4
Players	3-5
Tone	Horror mystery
Play Time	8-12 hours

KEY THEMES

Atmosphere	Creeping dread
Focus	Investigation
Conflict	Moral complexity
Agency	Multiple solutions
Horror	Environmental
Endings	Three outcomes

BACKGROUND

Centuries ago, a cult known as the **Children of the Dark Radiance** performed a profane ritual at a forest shrine, attempting to tear a hole between worlds and summon the **Whispering Hollow** — a lesser void entity that feeds on despair and fear. The ritual was interrupted by a coalition of druids and clerics. In the ensuing battle, the entity was partially summoned and then sealed within the shrine itself, trapped but not destroyed. The shrine was buried and its location struck from all records.

In recent months, the seal has begun to weaken. The entity's whispers have grown louder, reaching out to vulnerable minds in nearby settlements. Three villagers — Elara, Thomas, and Sara — have been drawn into the forest by dreams and compulsions. They now serve as thralls, their life force slowly feeding the entity and further weakening the seal.

PACING NOTES

Session 1: Arrive in Thornhaven, investigate disappearances, gather clues, interact with villagers.

Session 2: Journey into the Blackwood, survive environmental hazards, discover the shrine.

Session 3: Explore the shrine's outer chambers, confront thralls, piece together the history.

Session 4: Descend to the Inner Sanctum, face the entity's manifestation, resolve the adventure.

ADVENTURE HOOKS

Four ways to draw the party to Thornhaven

HOOK 1: THE DESPERATE PLEA

Elder Miriam of Thornhaven approaches the party at a nearby town, offering payment (50 gp) and supplies in exchange for investigating the disappearances of three villagers. She is direct, frightened, and running out of options. *Best for: parties who respond to clear quests and monetary rewards.*

HOOK 2: PERSONAL CONNECTION

One player character has family ties to Thornhaven. They receive an urgent letter from a worried relative describing strange lights in the forest and villagers acting strangely before vanishing. *Best for: campaigns where PCs have established backstories and regional ties.*

HOOK 3: THE SURVIVOR

While traveling, the party encounters a young woman stumbling out of the Blackwood, muttering about "blue lights" and "voices in the stones." She is **Sara Greenfield**, one of the missing villagers, but she escaped before being fully corrupted. She can provide a partial description of the shrine. *Best for: immediate action and mystery.*

HOOK 4: HIRED INVESTIGATORS

A minor noble with interests in the region hires the party to investigate reports of unnatural phenomena near Thornhaven. Payment is generous, but the noble's motives may be more than purely altruistic. *Best for: morally complex campaigns with political undertones.*

DM NOTE

During Session 0 or at the table, have players briefly describe where they are when the adventure begins (marketplace, inn, riverbank, etc.). This creates natural starting positions and investment in Thornhaven.

TONE & THEMES

- Environmental Horror:** The Blackwood itself is unsettling — twisted trees, unnatural silence, the constant sense of being watched.
- Investigation over Combat:** Clues, NPC interactions, and environmental storytelling drive the narrative. Combat is a tool, not the solution.
- Moral Complexity:** The thralls were once innocent villagers. Can they be saved, or must they be stopped?
- Player Agency:** Multiple solutions exist for most challenges, rewarding creativity and roleplaying.

PART 1: THORNHAVEN

A village gripped by fear

DANGER ●○○○○



Thornhaven — a modest farming community of roughly 200 souls

VILLAGE DESCRIPTION

"The village of Thornhaven sits in a valley where the Thornbrook River meets the edge of the Blackwood Forest. Fields of barley and rye surround a cluster of thatched cottages. A low stone wall, more symbolic than defensive, marks the village boundary. But something is wrong — doors are barred, parents keep children indoors, and the tavern is nearly empty."

The mood has shifted dramatically over the past two weeks. What was once a welcoming, close-knit community is now gripped by fear. Three villagers have vanished, and no one knows why.

KEY LOCATIONS IN THORNHAVEN

Elder's Longhouse: The largest building in Thornhaven — a timber-framed hall where Miriam conducts village business. The back room contains the Thornbrook family records dating back 300 years, including references to the "sealed place" in the Blackwood. DC 15 Investigation finds a hand-drawn map fragment showing a path into the forest, though the final portion has been deliberately torn away.

The Temple of the Harvest: A modest stone shrine tended by Brother Aldric. The altar still holds faint divine energy — holy water blessed here lasts twice as long. Aldric has been experiencing nightmares of a stone shrine with glowing runes (DC 10 Persuasion). The temple's small library contains local history, including a journal referencing the "Children of the Dark Radiance."

Garrett's Forge: The village blacksmith, recently abandoned. Elara's tools are still laid out as if she stepped away momentarily. The forge is cold — Garrett hasn't worked since she vanished. DC 12 Investigation finds fresh ash in the fireplace formed into strange patterns (Arcana DC 14 identifies partial summoning circles). Garrett will pay 20 gp for information about Elara.

Kessa's Hut: A small cottage on the village outskirts, surrounded by herb gardens and animal traps. Kessa knows the Blackwood better than anyone — she tracks game to its edge but never enters. Her hut contains dried herbs, poultices, and a hand-drawn map of the forest's safe paths (Survival checks in the Blackwood gain advantage if the party acquires it). She will guide the party to the forest's edge for 10 gp but refuses to go deeper.

The Market Square: Central gathering space, now eerily quiet. A notice board holds missing persons flyers and a warning from Elder Miriam about traveling after dark. DC 12 Perception notices fresh boot prints near the square's well — three sets, heading north toward the forest.

The Thornbrook Inn: A two-story building near the square, run by Mira Harrow. The common room is nearly empty these days, but Mira gossips freely for coin (5 sp buys a useful rumor). She's an informant for both the village council and anyone else who pays — betrays whoever seems weaker.

THE MISSING VILLAGERS

Three villagers have vanished over the past two weeks, each taken in the middle of the night. They walked into the forest willingly, as if in a trance, with no signs of struggle:

- ◆ **Elara Ironforge** (24) — Garrett's daughter, skilled apprentice smith, strong-willed and adventurous. She was the first to vanish, five nights ago. Her smithing tools were left behind — she never went anywhere without them. DC 12 Investigation of her workshop reveals ash in the fireplace formed into strange patterns (partial summoning circles). She had been acting strangely for days before vanishing — distracted, muttering in her sleep, waking with blue tinged eyes that faded by morning.

KEY NPCs OF THORNHAVEN

The villagers the party will meet



Elder Miriam Thornbrook — Village leader



Brother Aldric — Village priest

ELDER MIRIAM THORNBROOK

MEDIUM HUMANOID (HUMAN), LAWFUL NEUTRAL

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10	8	12	14	16	14
+0	-1	+1	+2	+3	+2

AC 10 | HP 9 (2d8) | Speed 30 ft.

Skills: Insight +5, Persuasion +4, History +4

Personality: Direct, no-nonsense, skeptical of magic but desperate enough to accept help. Goal: Bring the missing villagers home safely.

Information: Three villagers vanished over two weeks. Strange pale blue lights seen in the forest at night. Will pay 50 gp and provide supplies.

BROTHER ALDRIC

MEDIUM HUMANOID (HUMAN), NEUTRAL GOOD

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10	10	12	13	16	14
+0	+0	+1	+1	+3	+2

AC 10 | HP 11 (2d8+2) | Speed 30 ft.

Spellcasting (Cleric): DC 13, +5 to hit. *Cantrips:* guidance, sacred flame, thaumaturgy. *1st (4):* cure wounds, sanctuary, shield of faith, bless.

Personality: Anxious, well-meaning, deeply faithful but doubting his own adequacy. Goal: Protect his flock.

Information (DC 10 Persuasion): Nightmares of a stone shrine with glowing runes. Holy water seems ineffective. Mentions old legends about a "forgotten place" in the Blackwood.

MORE KEY NPCs

The blacksmith, the herbalist, and the child



Garrett the Smith — Grieving father



Kessa the Herbalist — Tracker and scout

GARRETT THE SMITH

MEDIUM HUMANOID (DWARF), CHAOTIC GOOD

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
16	10	14	12	10	8
+3	+0	+2	+1	+0	-1

AC 12 (leather apron) | HP 22 (4d8+4) | Speed 25 ft.

Skills: Athletics +5, Intimidation +1

Personality: Blunt, grieving, barely containing rage and desperation. Goal: Find his daughter Elara, alive or dead.

Information (DC 12 Persuasion): Elara left behind her smithing tools — she never went anywhere without them. Found fresh ash in her fireplace the morning she vanished, though she hadn't been working.

KESSA THE HERBALIST

MEDIUM HUMANOID (HALF-ELF), TRUE NEUTRAL

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10	14	12	13	16	10
+0	+2	+1	+1	+3	+0

AC 12 (leather) | HP 18 (4d8) | Speed 30 ft.

Skills: Nature +5, Perception +5, Survival +5, Stealth +4

Personality: Wary, practical, speaks bluntly, values competence over charm. Goal: Keep herself and Thornhaven safe.

Information (DC 13 Persuasion): Saw Thomas Fell walking toward the forest three nights ago, moving stiffly like a sleepwalker. Eyes glassy and unfocused. Can provide a rough map of the Blackwood (Survival checks gain advantage). Will guide the party to the forest edge for 10 gp.

CLUES & LEADS

What the party can discover in Thornhaven

YOUNG PIP — THE TRAUMATIZED CHILD

A curious 11-year-old who often played near the forest edge. He is the only person to have entered the Blackwood recently and returned — though not unchanged. **Personality:** Bright, inquisitive, traumatized but trying to seem brave. He feels guilty he couldn't save the others.

Information (DC 10 Persuasion): He wandered into the forest a week ago, drawn by "pretty lights" — pale blue orbs floating between the trees. He remembers walking through the woods for what felt like hours, the lights leading him deeper. He saw "a big stone door with glowing writing" before everything went dark. He woke up on the forest edge at dawn with no memory of how he got out.

He shows the party glowing marks on his arms — pale blue lines that pulse faintly in darkness (Medicine or Arcana DC 12 identifies them as Abyssal runes — a corruption mark from the entity's influence). The marks are fading but haven't disappeared completely. He has nightmares every night of a voice saying "*the veil thins, the seal breaks, the hollow calls.*" DC 13 Medicine recognizes the marks are slowly spreading — in a week, they'll reach his heart.

DM Note: Pip is a potential future victim. If the party doesn't resolve the shrine threat within a week, Pip will be drawn back into the Blackwood by the entity's call.

SEARCHING THE MISSING VILLAGERS' HOMES

Clues found in the victims' residences

GENERAL OBSERVATIONS

Each home shows signs of the occupant leaving in the middle of the night — cold hearth, unmade bed, door left ajar. No signs of struggle or violence. The following clues can be found with successful Investigation checks:

ELARA'S WORKSHOP (INVESTIGATION DC 12)

Her smithing tools are laid out neatly — she never went anywhere without them, yet she left them behind. Fresh ash in the fireplace is formed into strange spiral patterns. **Arcana DC 14:** Partial summoning circles — something was using her fireplace as a ritual focus while she slept. A half-finished horseshoe on the anvil has faint Abyssal runes scratched into the metal — Elara was unknowingly channeling entity influence through her work.

THOMAS'S HOME (INVESTIGATION DC 13)

A journal on the bedside table contains increasingly disturbed entries. Early entries describe grief over his wife's death. Later entries mention "a voice in the dreams" and "a place beneath the trees where she's waiting." The final entry, written the night before he vanished, reads: *"I can hear her singing. She's calling me home. The hollow place. I'm going to her tonight."* **DC 14 Insight:** The entity was exploiting his grief, impersonating his dead wife to lure him.

SARA'S HOME (INVESTIGATION DC 12)

A half-finished embroidery depicts a stylized sun — except the rays are twisted into unnatural spiral shapes. **Arcana DC 12:** Faint abjuration magic woven into the thread — Sara was unconsciously creating a protective charm, fighting the entity's influence through her craft. Her fiancé Petyr mentions she'd been having nightmares for a week, waking with pale blue marks on her arms. A love letter from Petyr on her bedside table is stained with tears — she knew something was wrong but couldn't explain it.

PATTERN RECOGNITION (DC 14 INSIGHT)

All three victims were vulnerable — Elara isolated and obsessive, Thomas grieving, Sara young and empathetic. The entity targets those whose minds are open to influence. The escalation is accelerating: Elara after two weeks of dreams, Thomas after one week, Sara after only three days. The seal is weakening. If the party doesn't act soon, more villagers will be taken.

RESEARCH: TEMPLE OR ELDER'S LONGHOUSE (INVESTIGATION DC 15)

300 years ago, a cult known as the **Children of the Dark Radiance** operated in this region. They worshipped a void entity they called the Whispering Hollow and attempted to summon it into the mortal world through a ritual at a forest shrine. The ritual was interrupted by a coalition of druids and clerics. In the ensuing battle, the entity was partially summoned and then sealed within the shrine itself — trapped but not destroyed.

The shrine was buried and its location deliberately forgotten. The druids placed awakened trees as guardians along the approach. The clerics consecrated the ground to suppress the entity's influence. One journal entry from Elder Miriam's family records reads: *"The seal holds, but it will not hold forever. The seal requires three anchors — faith, sacrifice, and will. If one fails, all fail. Future generations must be vigilant."*

DC 17 History or Religion: The "three anchors" correspond to three types of divine magic that reinforce the seal. The faith anchor is the temple's blessing (weakened — Aldric's prayers have been failing). The sacrifice anchor is the ward stones around Thornhaven (neglected — see Optional Side Quest). The will anchor is the druidic guardians (still active, but the trees are ancient and dying).

OPTIONAL SIDE QUEST: THE WARD STONES

Brother Aldric can suggest a side objective: ancient ward stones were placed around Thornhaven's perimeter centuries ago to keep the entity's influence at bay. Recent neglect has weakened them. Restoring the three ward stones provides a protective blessing (+1 to saving throws against enchantment spells for 24 hours) and slows the entity's ability to call new victims.

North Stone: Overgrown with thorny vines (Survival DC 12 to find, Strength DC 13 or slashing damage to clear). DC 15 Nature recognizes the vines are corrupted — they bleed purple sap when cut.

West Stone: Surrounded by aggressive wolves (2–3 wolves, frightened by the shrine's influence — they flee if reduced to half HP). DC 13 Animal Handling calms them enough to approach the stone.

South Stone: Partially submerged in a marsh (Athletics or Acrobatics DC 12 to reach without falling in). DC 14 Perception notices the water around the stone is faintly purple — the entity's influence is strongest here.

Re-sanctifying each stone requires a prayer or blessing from a divine caster (Religion DC 10), holy water, or creative player solutions. Each restored stone causes the blue lights in the forest to dim slightly — visible progress against the encroaching darkness.

PART 2: THE BLACKWOOD

Journey into darkness

DANGER ●●●○○



The Blackwood — ancient, dense, and unnaturally silent

THE BLACKWOOD FOREST

"The trees close in around you like a living wall. The canopy above is so thick that barely any sunlight reaches the forest floor. The air is cool and damp, carrying the scent of moss and decay. And it's quiet — unnaturally quiet. No birdsong. No rustling of small animals. Just the sound of your own breathing and the occasional whisper that might be the wind... or might not."

The Blackwood is an ancient, dense forest of towering oaks, gnarled roots, and thick undergrowth. As the party ventures deeper, they notice unsettling details: trees grow in twisted patterns, the forest is unnaturally quiet, and occasionally they hear distant whispers carried on the wind.

NAVIGATION AND SURVIVAL

The journey from Thornhaven to the shrine is roughly 4 miles through difficult terrain.

Without Kessa's Map: DC 15 Survival check every hour of travel. Failure means the party goes off course and encounters a hazard.

With Kessa's Map: Survival checks have advantage, and the party reaches the shrine without additional encounters unless they deliberately explore.

RANDOM ENCOUNTERS (OPTIONAL)

- Roll 1d6 every hour of travel. On a 1–2, the party encounters one of the following:
- ◆ **1. Corrupted Wildlife:** A pack of 2d4 wolves with matted fur and glowing eyes attacks. They fight with unnatural ferocity but flee if reduced to half their number.
 - ◆ **2. Tangled Undergrowth:** DC 12 Dexterity save or take 1d4 piercing damage and be restrained (DC 12 Strength to break free).
 - ◆ **3. Will-o'-Wisps:** 1d3 will-o'-wisps appear, trying to lure the party off the path. DC 13 Wisdom save to resist.
 - ◆ **4. The Hanging Tree:** A massive dead tree with humanoid bark formations hanging from branches in a ritualistic pattern (DC 14 Perception).
 - ◆ **5. Ghostly Whispers:** "Turn back... you are not ready... the hollow hungers." DC 11 Wisdom save or gain one level of exhaustion.
 - ◆ **6. Safe Haven:** An old druid circle radiates faint abjuration magic. Short rest here grants advantage on saves against the entity's influence.

KEY ENCOUNTERS

Guardians and the shrine entrance

THE FOREST GUARDIANS

About halfway to the shrine, the party encounters **two awakened trees** standing sentinel across the path. These trees were placed by the original druids to guard the approach. They are not evil, but they are ancient and suspicious.

Avoiding Combat: The trees do not speak Common, but a character who speaks Druidic or Sylvan can communicate with them.

- ◆ **DC 13 Persuasion:** Convince the trees the party intends to reinforce the seal, not break it.
- ◆ **DC 15 Nature:** Explain that the seal is failing and the forest itself is at risk.
- ◆ **DC 12 Druidic/Sylvan:** The trees recognize the old language and allow passage if the party swears an oath to protect the forest.

Reward for Peaceful Resolution: Each character gains 5 temporary hit points and advantage on their next saving throw.

If the party attacks: The trees fight to incapacitate (not kill), grappling characters until they calm down or escape.

AWAKENED TREE

LARGE PLANT, UNALIGNED

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
19	6	15	10	12	7
+4	-2	+2	+0	+1	-1

AC 13 (natural armor) | HP 59 (7d10+21) | Speed 20 ft.

Damage Vulnerabilities: fire | **Damage Resistances:** bludgeoning, piercing

False Appearance: While motionless, the tree is indistinguishable from a normal tree.

Actions: *Slam.* +6 to hit, reach 10 ft., 3d6+4 bludgeoning. *Grasping Roots.* +6 to hit, reach 15 ft., target is restrained (escape DC 14).



ARRIVAL AT THE SHRINE ENTRANCE

"The trees part to reveal a clearing shrouded in unnatural mist. At the center stands a crumbling stone archway, overgrown with dark vines and faintly glowing with blue runes. Fresh footprints lead into the archway — three sets, matching the missing villagers."

Perception DC 12: Fresh footprints leading into the archway — three sets.

Arcana DC 13: The runes are Abyssal and serve as both seal and warning. Translated: "*Here lies the Hollow. Let none disturb its rest.*"

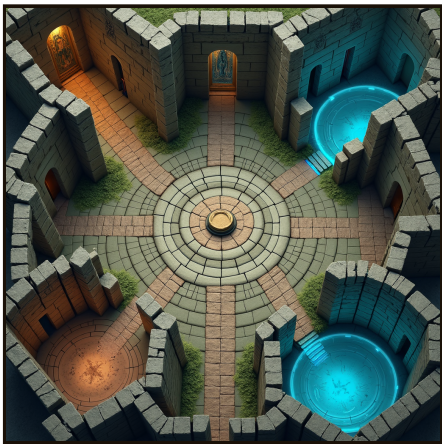
Religion DC 14: The archway was once consecrated ground. Divine magic still lingers, but it is fading rapidly.

Each character must succeed on a **DC 10 Wisdom save** or feel an overwhelming compulsion to descend immediately.

PART 3: THE FORGOTTEN SHRINE

Beneath the Blackwood, the seal weakens

DANGER ●●●●○



The Forgotten Shrine — ancient stone halls beneath the forest

GENERAL FEATURES

- Light:** The runes provide dim light throughout the shrine. Darkness spells function normally.
- Ceilings:** 15 feet high in most chambers, 25 feet in the sanctum.
- Doors:** Heavy stone slabs requiring a DC 13 Strength check to open, or they can be wedged open with pitons or crowbars.
- Atmosphere:** The shrine radiates unease. Characters with darkvision notice shadows moving where nothing should be. Spellcasters feel a faint resistance when casting — not enough to prevent magic, but enough to be unsettling.

S1: ENTRANCE HALL

- A long, narrow hallway slopes downward, lined with alcoves containing skeletal remains. Each alcove holds the bones of a cultist who died during the original battle. The air is cold and still.
- Perception DC 12:** One skeleton in the third alcoid on the left is different — its skull is cracked, and faint necrotic energy still clings to the bones.
- Investigation DC 14:** A hidden compartment beneath that skeleton contains a *potion of healing* and a yellowed journal page describing the ritual that created the seal.
- Trap:** The fourth alcove on the right contains a pressure plate. If triggered, a portcullis slams down, dividing the party (DC 15 Strength to lift or DC 13 Thieves' Tools to bypass).

S2: HALL OF ECHOES

- A large, circular chamber with a high ceiling. The walls are covered in faded murals depicting a ritual — figures in dark robes gathered around a glowing pit, with a massive shadow rising behind them. Other figures — druids and clerics — stand opposed, hands raised in prayer.
- Insight or History DC 12:** The murals depict the battle that sealed the shrine.
- Perception DC 13:** Three exits — north (heavily sealed stone door, DC 15 Strength), east and west (open).
- Encounter — Echoes of the Past:** When the party enters, ghostly voices replay the final moments of the battle. The echoes manifest as **2-4 shadows** (use Shadow stat block). These are psychic impressions, not true undead. They attack anyone who enters but cannot leave the chamber. *Scaling: 2 shadows for 3 players, 4 for 5 players.*

SHRINE ROOMS

West path, East path, and the Thralls

S3: THE OSSUARY (WEST PATH)

A chamber filled with bones stacked in macabre patterns along the walls. At the center is a stone altar covered in dried black residue. The air smells of old death and something else — something sweet and wrong.

Investigation DC 13: The bones are humanoid, many showing signs of ritualistic violence — deliberate cuts, burn marks, and symbols carved into the bone.

Religion DC 14: This was a sacrificial chamber. The cult believed that offering life force would weaken the barrier between worlds.

Hidden Treasure (Investigation DC 15): Behind a false panel in the altar: 75 gp in ancient coins, a +1 *dagger* with Abyssal runes (non-cursed), and a *scroll of protection from evil and good*.

Trap: If the altar is disturbed without first consecrating the room (Religion DC 12 or holy water), the bones animate and attack as a skeleton swarm.

S4: THE FLOODED PASSAGE (EAST PATH)

A long corridor partially flooded with stagnant water (3 feet deep). The water is murky and cold. Something moves beneath the surface.

Encounter — Waterlogged Dead: 2 zombies rise from the water and attack. They are slow but relentless.

Environmental Hazard: The water is difficult terrain. Each round a character ends their turn in the water, DC 10 Constitution save or gain one level of exhaustion from the bone-chilling cold.

Alternate Path: A ledge runs along the left wall (Acrobatics DC 12 to traverse without falling in).

ZOMBIE

MEDIUM UNDEAD, NEUTRAL EVIL

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
13	6	16	3	6	5
+1	-2	+3	-4	-2	-3

AC 8 | HP 22 (3d8+9) | Speed 20 ft.

Undead Fortitude: If damage reduces the zombie to 0 HP, it must make a DC 5+damage Constitution save. On a success, the zombie drops to 1 HP instead.

Actions: *Slam.* +3 to hit, 1d6+1 bludgeoning.

S5: THE THRALLS' LAIR

This chamber has been converted into a makeshift camp. Bedrolls, scattered supplies, and a small fire pit occupy the center. The missing villagers are here — but they are not themselves.

"The missing villagers are alive but changed. Their eyes glow faintly blue, their movements are stiff and mechanical, and they speak in unison with a voice that is not their own: 'You should not have come. The veil thins. The seal breaks. The Hollow calls. We will complete the circle. You cannot stop what has already begun.'"

Encounter — The Thralls: The three missing villagers (Elara, Thomas, Sara) attack as thralls of the Hollow. They fight with unnatural coordination but without skill or creativity. Use the **Commoner** stat block with the following modifications: HP 15 each, their attacks deal an additional 1d4 psychic damage, and they are immune to the frightened condition.

Saving the Thralls: *Dispel Magic* (DC 12) on each thrall. *Protection from Evil and Good* suppresses the charm. Destroying the runic circle (AC 15, 20 HP, Investigation DC 13 to identify weak points) frees them.

Moral Choice: If the party kills the thralls, Thornhaven will mourn but understand. If they save them, the village celebrates — but the entity's influence lingers until the seal is addressed.

INNER SANCTUM

The heart of the shrine — and the entity's prison

DANGER ●●●●●

S6: THE ARCHIVE

A small chamber lined with shelves containing rotted scrolls and books. Most are illegible, but a few remain intact.

Investigation DC 12: The party finds a ritual diagram showing how the seal was created (Religion or Arcana DC 14 to understand), notes describing the Whispering Hollow as a "lesser void entity" that feeds on despair and fear, and a warning: *"The seal requires three anchors — faith, sacrifice, and will. If one fails, all fail."*

S7: INNER SANCTUM

"The final chamber is a vast, circular room with a high, domed ceiling. At the center is a deep pit — 20 feet across — glowing with pale blue light. The whispers are deafening here, not just heard but felt, vibrating in your bones and teeth."

As the party enters, the whispers coalesce into a single, resonant voice: *"At last... the seal crumbles... I taste the air of your world once more... Free me, and I shall grant you power beyond imagining... resist, and I shall feast on your despair..."*



The Whispering Hollow — Manifestation of the void entity

MANIFESTATION OF THE WHISPERING HOLLOW

MEDIUM UNDEAD (MANIFESTATION), CHAOTIC EVIL

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
14	16	14	10	12	16
+2	+3	+2	+0	+1	+3

AC 13 | HP 45 (6d8+18) | Speed 0 ft., fly 40 ft. (hover)

Damage Resistances: acid, cold, fire, lightning, thunder; bludgeoning, piercing, and slashing from nonmagical attacks

Damage Immunities: necrotic, poison

Condition Immunities: charmed, exhaustion, frightened, grappled, paralyzed, petrified, poisoned, prone, restrained

Whispers of Despair (Aura): Any creature that starts its turn within 10 feet of the manifestation must succeed on a DC 13 Wisdom saving throw or be frightened until the start of its next turn.

Incorporeal Movement: The manifestation can move through other creatures and objects as if they were difficult terrain. It takes 5 force damage if it ends its turn inside an object.

Actions: *Life Drain.* +5 to hit, reach 5 ft., 3d6 necrotic damage. Target must succeed on a DC 13 Constitution save or its HP maximum is reduced by the damage taken. *Void Lash (Recharge 5–6).* +5 to hit, reach 15 ft., 4d6 psychic damage.

Scaling: For a weaker party, reduce HP to 30 and lower save DCs by 1. For a stronger party, add 1d4 shadow minions.

RESOLVING THE ADVENTURE

Three paths, three consequences

OPTION 1: REINFORCE THE SEAL

Using the information from the Archive, the party can reinforce the seal by performing a combined ritual. This requires: a spellcaster with at least one 1st-level spell slot, a DC 14 Religion or Arcana check, and a symbolic sacrifice (holy water, a treasured item, or a drop of blood).

Success: The seal strengthens, the manifestation dissipates with a shriek, and the shrine goes dormant. The whispers fade. The Blackwood will slowly heal over the coming months. This is the "safe" ending.

OPTION 2: DESTROY THE SHRINE

The party can collapse the shrine entirely, burying the pit and the entity beneath tons of stone. This requires: destroying the three support pillars (AC 17, 30 HP each, vulnerability to thunder damage), a DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation) check to identify structural weak points, and escaping before the ceiling collapses (DC 12 Dexterity save or 3d6 bludgeoning damage).

Success: The shrine is destroyed and the entity is trapped indefinitely. However, the Blackwood becomes permanently dangerous — a corrupted wasteland that will spread slowly outward. Thornhaven may need to relocate within a generation.

OPTION 3: BANISH THE ENTITY

A high-risk option. The party can attempt to banish the Whispering Hollow permanently using powerful magic. This requires: a 4th-level spell slot or a scroll of banishment, a DC 16 Arcana check to modify the spell, and the manifestation must be reduced to 0 HP first.

Success: The entity is banished to its home plane and the shrine becomes inert. This is the "heroic" ending — the best possible outcome.

Failure: The entity breaks free. The party must flee or face a more powerful manifestation (DM's discretion — this could be a TPK or a dramatic escape scene).



CONCLUSION AND REWARDS

If the Seal is Reinforced: The party returns to Thornhaven as heroes. The missing villagers (if saved) are reunited with their families. Elder Miriam weeps with relief. The village holds a feast. Garrett gives the party his finest weapon (a +1 warhammer or longsword). Brother Aldric consecrates a holy symbol for each party member (+1 to Religion checks). The party gains the "Protectors of Thornhaven" reputation.

If the Shrine is Destroyed: The immediate threat is ended, but the Blackwood becomes a corrupted wasteland. Thornhaven survives but must live with the consequences. Same rewards, but the party earns a reputation as "ruthless but effective."

If the Entity is Banished: A legendary victory. Songs are sung of their bravery. A powerful NPC offers the party a scroll of lesser restoration or a rare potion. The party earns the "Banishers of the Hollow" title.

EXPERIENCE POINTS

Investigating Thornhaven thoroughly: **100 XP** per character

Surviving the Blackwood journey: **150 XP** per character

Resolving the Forest Guardians peacefully: **100 XP** per character (or 200 XP if defeated)

Each random encounter: **50-100 XP** per character

Defeating or saving the thralls: **200 XP** per character

Resolving the final encounter: **300-500 XP** per character

Total XP Range: 900-1,300 XP per character — enough to reach level 2 or progress toward level 3.

APPENDIX

Tips for Game Masters

TIPS FOR NEW GAME MASTERS

- Atmosphere is Key:** Use descriptive language to emphasize the unsettling nature of the Blackwood and the shrine. Play ambient music if possible. Dim the lights.
- Flexibility:** If the party pursues unexpected solutions, reward creativity. The adventure is designed to be flexible.
- NPC Voices:** Give each NPC a distinct voice or mannerism (Elder Miriam speaks curtly, Brother Aldric stammers when nervous, Garrett grunts).
- Pacing:** Don't rush. Let the investigation in Thornhaven breathe. Let the party feel the tension of the forest. Build suspense gradually.
- Player Agency:** Present problems, not solutions. Let the players decide how to approach each challenge.

ADJUSTING DIFFICULTY

- Easier:** Reduce enemy HP by 25%, lower save DCs by 1-2, provide healing potions as loot.
- Harder:** Add additional enemies to encounters, increase save DCs by 1-2, introduce time pressure (the seal weakens each day).

EXPANDING THE ADVENTURE

- Prequel Hook:** The party hears rumors of similar disappearances in other villages, suggesting the Whispering Hollow's influence extends further than anyone knew.
- Sequel Hook:** If the entity is not banished, its influence lingers. Months later, the party encounters cultists trying to rebuild the shrine.
- Side Quests:** Introduce a rival adventuring party also investigating the shrine, creating tension and potential conflict.
- Character Ties:** Connect one PC's backstory to the original druids or cultists, adding personal stakes.

COMMON PLAYER QUESTIONS

- "Can we take a long rest in the shrine?"** The oppressive atmosphere makes it impossible. The party must rest outside the shrine entrance or in Thornhaven.
- "Can we negotiate with the Whispering Hollow?"** The entity is malevolent but intelligent. It will promise anything to be freed, but it cannot be trusted. Any deal it offers will have a hidden cost.
- "What if we kill the thralls?"** This is a valid choice with emotional consequences. Thornhaven mourns, but the party is not blamed. Garrett, however, will never forgive them.
- "Can we recruit the awakened trees?"** If the party convinced the trees peacefully, they might agree to guard the shrine entrance after the adventure.

DESIGNER'S NOTES

ABOUT THIS ADVENTURE

Shadows of the Forgotten Shrine was designed to introduce new Game Masters to adventure design principles: clear objectives, multiple solutions, NPCs with motivations, and a balance of combat, exploration, and social interaction.

The adventure balances classic dungeon crawl elements with modern design philosophy: NPCs with motivations, moral complexity, and player agency. The three possible endings ensure that the party's choices matter and that there is no single "correct" solution.

The Whispering Hollow is deliberately kept vague, allowing Game Masters to expand its lore in future campaigns. Is it truly a void entity? A demon? An elder evil? The answer is whatever best serves your game.

For experienced Game Masters, this adventure serves as a one-shot or campaign starter, with hooks leading to deeper mysteries in the Blackwood and beyond.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Helm Evans creates D&D 5e adventures and RPG resources for Game Masters seeking atmospheric, player-driven narratives with meaningful choices. With a background in game design and a love of gothic horror, Helm's adventures emphasize exploration, investigation, and moral complexity over pure combat.

Shadows of the Forgotten Shrine is Helm's first published adventure module — the first book in The Shattered Veil series.

"When the seal breaks, the shadows remember."

THE SHATTERED VEIL SERIES

Book 1 of 5 — Shadows of the Forgotten Shrine
Next: The Chalice of False Salvation (Levels 3-5)

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